CIVITAS: Civic Accountability Platform

Hold Power. Amplify People. Strengthen Democracy.

Harsh Nalawade, Siddhi Lokhande, Prachi Pandit
Team Nagriks
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Abstract

CIVITAS is a next-generation civic accountability platform designed to bridge the persistent gap between citizens and their elected representatives. By combining real-time complaint management, AI-driven routing, transparent financial dashboards, and a public scoring system, CIVITAS transforms democracy from a periodic electoral event into a continuous, data-driven accountability loop. Built for hackathon demonstration and designed for real-world scalability, CIVITAS targets urban and semi-urban citizens across India, with a roadmap to expand nationally and internationally. The platform empowers every citizen to become an active stakeholder in governance — not just once every five years, but every single day.

Keywords — *civic technology, e-governance, accountability, complaint management, transparency, democratic participation*

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II. INTRODUCTION

Contemporary democracies face a systemic paradox: while digital connectivity has transformed commerce, communication, and entertainment, civic participation and government accountability remain largely unchanged from pre-digital paradigms. Citizens engage meaningfully with their representatives only during election cycles, after which the accountability loop effectively breaks down.

CIVITAS addresses this gap by providing a unified digital infrastructure that enables continuous, real-time civic engagement. The platform operationalizes democratic accountability — translating abstract governance principles into measurable, publicly visible metrics that persist between elections.

This document presents the technical and functional specification of CIVITAS as developed for ByteBattle Hackathon 2026. It covers the platform's problem context, solution architecture, module specifications, user roles, projected impact, and development roadmap.

III. PROBLEM STATEMENT

Despite widespread adoption of digital services, civic governance in most democracies suffers from four deep-rooted systemic failures, as summarized in Table I.

TABLE I. Systemic Failures in Civic Governance

No.	Problem	Impact
1	No system to track political promises post-election	Accountability is lost after voting day
2	Inefficient complaint systems with no structured follow-up	Citizens feel ignored; issues remain unresolved
3	Lack of transparency in public spending	Corruption thrives in informational opacity
4	Low citizen engagement between elections	Governance feedback loop is effectively broken

The core issue is structural: democracy functions as a five-year event rather than a continuous, participatory process. Citizens have no real-time visibility into how promises are kept or public funds are spent. Officials face no structured accountability mechanism between election cycles. CIVITAS is designed to resolve each of these failure modes through an integrated, data-driven platform.

IV. SOLUTION OVERVIEW

CIVITAS is a unified digital platform that addresses each of the four identified systemic problems through four deeply integrated modules. Together, these modules form a closed-loop accountability system in which every action — a complaint filed, a budget published, a promise broken — is recorded, scored, and made publicly visible. Table II provides an overview of the module-to-problem mapping.

TABLE II. CIVITAS Module-to-Problem Mapping

Module	Problem Addressed	Key Capability
AUTHORIZATION	No promise tracking	Public performance scoring for elected officials
OPINION	Broken complaint systems	Geo-tagged issue reporting with AI-assisted routing
ASSEMBLY	Low citizen engagement	Open civic discussions, polls, and structured debates
FINANCIAL RESERVE	Opacity in public spending	Real-time government expenditure dashboard

V. KEY FEATURES

A. AUTHORIZATION – Performance Scoring

A transparent, algorithm-driven scoring system that rates elected officials and public servants based on promise fulfillment, complaint resolution speed, and budget transparency. Scores are publicly visible and updated continuously.

B. OPINION – Issue Reporting

Citizens can report civic issues with photo evidence and precise geo-tagging. AI automatically classifies the complaint and routes it to the responsible authority, assigning a resolution deadline with escalation triggers.

C. ASSEMBLY – Public Forum

A moderated digital space for civic discourse. Citizens can raise topics, debate policy decisions, vote on community priorities, and engage directly with public officials in structured threads.

D. FINANCIAL RESERVE – Budget Transparency

An open-data financial dashboard connecting to government expenditure APIs. Citizens can drill down into ward-level, department-level, and project-level spending through visual charts and data export functionality.

VI. OPINION – ISSUE REPORTING MODULE

The OPINION module is the citizen's primary touchpoint with local governance. It transforms informal complaints into structured, trackable, time-bound accountability requests. The workflow proceeds through five stages, as described below.

1) Citizen Reports Issue: The citizen uploads a photograph, enters a description, and provides GPS location data.
2) Smart Authority Routing: A geo-matching algorithm assigns the complaint to the correct department.
3) Deadline Assignment: An SLA-based deadline is set according to the issue priority tier.
4) Resolution and Confirmation: The responsible official closes the ticket; the citizen may confirm resolution or escalate.

Table III specifies the technical attributes of the OPINION module.

TABLE III. OPINION Module Technical Attributes

Attribute	Details
Issue Categories	Roads, Water, Sanitation, Electricity, Public Safety, Parks
SLA Tiers	Critical: 24 hrs | High: 3 days | Medium: 7 days | Low: 14 days
Escalation	Auto-escalation to senior officer if deadline missed; score penalty applied
Notifications	SMS and push alerts at each status change for both citizen and officer
Evidence Support	Images, video clips (max 30 seconds), and voice notes

VII. AUTHORIZATION – SCORING SYSTEM

The AUTHORIZATION module is CIVITAS's core accountability engine. Every official receives a publicly visible Accountability Score — a numerical rating reflecting real-time performance across promise fulfillment, complaint resolution, and budget disclosure. Table IV details the scoring criteria.

TABLE IV. Accountability Score Criteria

Action	Type	Points
Promise fulfilled on time	Positive	+15
Citizen complaint resolved within SLA	Positive	+10
Budget data published and verified	Positive	+8
Active participation in Assembly forum	Positive	+5
Missed complaint resolution deadline	Negative	−5
Broken or unfulfilled promise	Negative	−20

Action	Type	Points
Repeated failures (3 or more in 30 days)	Negative	−15
Unresolved escalated complaint	Negative	−10

Officials are categorized into five score bands, each with defined consequences and public visibility, as shown in Table V.

TABLE V. Accountability Score Bands and Consequences

Score Range	Rating	Consequence
850 – 1000	Excellent	Featured on platform; eligible for formal commendation
650 – 849	Good	Positive public visibility
400 – 649	Average	Monitored; public advisory notice issued
200 – 399	Poor	Official inquiry triggered
0 – 199	Critical	Public censure; parliamentary referral initiated

VIII. ASSEMBLY – PUBLIC FORUM

ASSEMBLY provides the deliberative democracy layer of CIVITAS. It offers a structured, moderated digital forum where citizens and officials engage in substantive civic discourse — moving beyond social media noise into purposeful, outcome-oriented communication. Table VI summarizes the features of this module.

TABLE VI. ASSEMBLY Module Features

Feature	Description
Topic Threads	Citizens post issues, proposals, or feedback on local policies
Upvote / Downvote	Community surfaces the most critical civic topics through democratic ranking
Official Responses	Officials are notified of high-traction threads and are required to respond
Polls and Surveys	Quick opinion polls on development projects and budget priorities
AI Moderation	NLP filters automatically remove spam, hate speech, and off-topic content
Thread Archiving	All discussions are archived for public audit and academic research

IX. FINANCIAL RESERVE – BUDGET TRANSPARENCY

The FINANCIAL RESERVE module connects directly to government open-data APIs (data.gov.in) to surface real-time public expenditure data. Citizens can explore how their tax money is allocated and spent at ward, district, department, and project levels. Table VII details the data layers and their refresh rates.

TABLE VII. FINANCIAL RESERVE Data Layers

X. USER ROLES AND ACCESS CONTROL

CIVITAS implements role-based access control (RBAC) following the principle of least privilege. Table VIII defines the five user roles and their respective capabilities.

TABLE VIII. User Roles and Access Levels

Role	Access Level	Primary Actions	Can View Score?
Citizen	Standard	Report issues, vote in polls, view budgets, forum posts	Yes (read-only)
Elected Official	Enhanced	Respond to complaints, update promises, post updates	Yes (own score)
Government Officer	Departmental	Manage assigned complaints, update resolutions	Department scores
Auditor	Privileged Read	Verify budget data, review score history, export reports	All scores
Platform Admin	Full	Moderate forum, configure SLAs, manage accounts	All data

XI. IMPACT AND OUTCOMES

Based on comparable civic technology deployments in India (Kerala's Janamaitri, Andhra Pradesh's Spandana) and global governance benchmarks, CIVITAS projects the following measurable outcomes within 24 months of full-scale deployment.

TABLE IX. Projected Impact Metrics (24-Month Horizon)

Metric	Projected Outcome
Official Accountability	3x increase relative to baseline
Citizen Participation	60% higher engagement rate
Corruption Index	40% reduction in petty corruption incidents
Public Trust	2x increase in institutional trust ratings

Table X summarizes the direct and long-term benefits for each stakeholder group.

TABLE X. Stakeholder Benefits

Stakeholder	Direct Benefit	Long-Term Impact
Citizens	Faster complaint resolution, visible spending data	Restored trust in governance institutions
Officials	Clear performance feedback, improved public image	Data-driven governance culture
Government	Reduced grievance backlog, open data baseline	Improved international governance rankings
Society	Reduced petty corruption, higher civic literacy	Strengthened democratic institutions

XII. PRODUCT ROADMAP

CIVITAS is designed for phased deployment, beginning with a single-city pilot and scaling to national and international coverage over three years. Table XI outlines the five-phase development and rollout plan.

TABLE XI. CIVITAS Product Roadmap

Phase	Timeline	Milestone	Target Users	Key Deliverable
1 – Pilot	Months 1–4	Single city launch	10,000	Core platform: OPINION + AUTHORIZATION
2 – Growth	Months 5–9	Multi-city expansion	100,000	ASSEMBLY + FINANCIAL RESERVE modules
3 – Scale	Months 10–18	State-level rollout	1,000,000+	AI enhancements and open API
4 – National	Year 2+	National deployment	All citizens	Full suite with NGO integrations
5 – Global	Year 3+	International expansion	Global	Multi-language, multi-government support

XIII. REFERENCES

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